SAPIENZA
UNIVERSITÀ DI ROMA

Faculty of Information Engineering, Informatics and Statistics
Department of Computer Science

Consurrent Systems

Author:
Simone Lidonnici

2 march 2026

Contents

1 Concurrency **1**
1.1 Mutex 1
1.1.1 Atomic Read/Write registers 2
1.1.2 Peterson algorithm 2

1
Concurrency

A Concurrent System is a set of sequential state machines that run simultaneously and interact through a shared medium. The goal is to combine the work of different processes, that solve different tasks in parallel.
We will focus on concurrent systems that have 3 main properties:

- **Reliable**: every process correctly executes its program.
- **Asynchronous**: each process has its own clock.
- **Shared memory**: every process has a local memory but there are some registries that can be accesseb by every process.

The number of processors that we have is not relevant so we will assume we have one for every process.
Synchronization of a concurrent systems means that the behaviour of one process depends on the behaviour of the other processes. There are two principal interactions:

- Cooperation: different processes work to make all succeed in their task.
- Competition: different processes aims to execute the same action, but only some of the succeed. This is usually when trying to access a shared resource.

1.1 Mutex

A mutex ensures that a part of the code is executed as if it was atomic, so without other processes running in between. The mutex is needed only in code parts that interact with shared data.

Critical section

A **critical section (CS)** is a set of code parts that must be excuted without interferences. When a process is in a CS, no other process can be in a CS for the same shared object.

The mutex problem is designig an entry protocol **lock** and an exit protocol **unlock**, such that the code encapsulated between this two protocols can be run by at most one process at a time.
Every mutex should satisfy 2 properties:

- **Safety**: there is at most one process in a CS.

- **Liveness**: something good everntually happen. This property has various options:
  - **Deadlock starvation**: if there is at least one invocation of lock, eventually after at least one process enters a CS.
  - **Starvation freedom**: every invocation of lock eventually grants access to the associated CS.
  - **Bounded bypass**: with n processes, there exists $f : N \to N$ such that every lock enters the CS after at most $f(n)$ other CS (processes).

The liveness properties have a hierarchy such that Bounded bypass implies Starvation freedom that also implies Deadlock freedom.

1.1.1 Atomic Read/Write registers

Atomic Read/Write registers are storage units that can be accessed through two operations (`READ` and `WRITE`) such that:

1. Each invocation of an operation:
   - looks instantaneous and can be considered as a single point on the timeline (there exists a function $t : OpInv \to \mathbb{R}^+$)
   - may be located in any point between its starting and ending time (we have that $t(opInv) \in [t_{start}(opInv), t_{end}(opInv)]$)
   - does not happen together with any other operation ($t(opInv) \neq t(opInv')$)
2. Every `READ` returns the preceeding value written in the register.

There are different types of registers based on wheter they can be read and written by one or many different processes:

- single-read/single-write (SRSW)
- single-read/multiple-write (SRMW)
- multiple-read/single-write (MRSW)
- multiple-read/multiple-write (MRMW)

1.1.2 Peterson algorithm

The Peterson algorithm designs a mutex for 2 processes:

Algorithm: Peterson algorithm (2 processes)

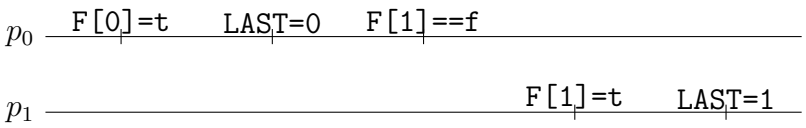
```
// Inizialize FLAG[i] as false
def lock(i):
    FLAG[i] = true
    LAST = i
    wait (FLAG[i-1] = false or LAST != i)
    return

def unlock(i):
    FLAG[i] = false
    return
```

This algorithm requires 2 one-bit MRSW registers for the `FLAG` and 1 one-bit MRMW register for `LAST`. Every lock-unlock requires 5 accesses to the registers.

Proof:

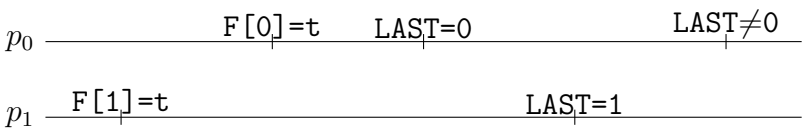
We can prove that the algorithm works by contraddiction, assuming that the two processes p_0 and p_1 are inside the CS. How has p_0 entered the CS:

1. If `FLAG[i]=false` that is possible with this sequence:



   With this sequence p_1 cannot be in the CS because `LAST=1` and `FLAG[0]=true`.

2. If `LAST=1` that is possible with this sequence:



   With this sequence p_1 cannot be in the CS because `LAST=1` and `FLAG[0]=true`.

Bounded bypass

The Peterson algorithm has the bounded bypass property with bound 1.

Proof:

Let p_0 invock lock, if it wins waits 0, otherwise must be `FLAG[1]=true` and `LAST=0`.
`FLAG[1]=true` means that p_1 has invocked the lock and will eventually enter the CS and unlock, putting the flag down. Now p_1 could invock the lock again:

- If it never locks again p_0 will eventually read the flag down and enter the CS, waiting 1.
- If p_1 locks again:
  - If p_0 reads `FLAG[1]` before p_1 locks again, then p_0 enters the CS, waiting 1.
  - If p_0 doesn't read before p_1 locks again, then p_1 will set `LAST=1` and will wait, so p_0 will eventually read `LAST` and enter the CS, waiting 1.

There is also a Peterson algorithm for an arbitrary number of processes n, using levels:

Algorithm: Peterson algorithm (n processes)

```
// Inizialize FLAG[i] as false
def lock(i):
    for lev in [1,n-1] :
        FLAG[i] = lev
        LAST[lev] = i
        wait (∀k FLAG[k] < lev or LAST[lev] != i)
    return

def unlock(i):
    FLAG[i] = 0
    return
```

This algorithm require n MRSW registers with $\lceil \log n \rceil$ bits for `FLAG` and $n-1$ MRSW registers with $\lceil \log n \rceil$ bits for `LAST`. Every lock-unlock requires $(n-1)(n+2)$ accesses to the registers, so has a cost $O(n^2)$.

Max processes at every level

For every level $l \in [0, n-1]$, there are at most $n-l$ processes in the level l. The mutex works for $l = n-1$.

Proof:
Proof by induction on the level l:

1. Base case: $l = 0$
2. Induction: a process p can increase its level by writing its `FLAG` at $l+1$ and its index in `LAST[l+1]`. Let p_x be the last one that writes `LAST[l+1]=x`, for p_x to pass at level $l+1$, it must be that $\forall k$ `FLAG[k]<l+1`. So, p_x is the only proc at level $l+1$.

   Otherwise, p_x is blocked in the wait and so we have at most $n-l-1$ processes at level $l+1$, those at level l, that by induction are at most $n-l$, except for p_x that is blocked in its $(l+1)$-th wait.

Starvation freedom

Every process that invokes lock and is at level $l \leq n-1$ eventually wins and eneters the CS.

Proof:
Proof by reverse induction on the level l:

1. Base case: $l = n-1$
2. Induction: assume a p_x is blocked at level l, so $\exists k$ `FLAG[k]`$\geq$`l+1` $\wedge$ `LAST[l+1]=x`. If some p_y sets `LAST[l+1]=y` p_x will exit from its wait and pass to level $l+1$.

   Otherwise, let $G = \{p_i |$ `FLAG[i]` $\geq$ `l+1`$\}$ and $L = \{p_i |$`FLAG[i]<l+1`$\}$. Every $p \in L$ will never enter its $(l+1)$-th loop and every $p \in G$ will eventually win and move into L. Eventually, p_x will be the only one in its $(l+1)$-th loop, with all other processes at level $l' < l+1$ and p_x will eventually pass to level $l+1$ and win.

The algorithm doesn't satisfy bounded bypass because if a process is sleeping the other can enter the CS an unbounded number of times.